of a long day's play, as ever thinking of somebody else, 'that was a great cover drive when you were on 42.'

He used to call me Bunk and I used to called him Trunk; I have no idea why.

Most remarkably, he continued to give time and support under the most trying circumstances, even when his own place in the team was being threatened. At various times, the national selectors were tempted to ask me to keep wicket instead of him, creating a space to include another specialist batsman or bowler. This was rarely a good idea because he was a world-class wicketkeeper and I was not; and, in every form of the game, picking the best available keeper generally makes sense. But even in these times when we were cast as direct rivals, he remained my greatest supporter, my role model and my big brother.

It is Monday, 9 July 2012, a warm summer's afternoon in England, and the Proteas are fielding against Somerset at Taunton in a warm-up match before the first Test at The Oval.

Bouch is keeping wicket and, at the age of 35, he seems as fit, eager and motivated as ever, determined to do well in what he has already announced will be his last Test series before retirement. Imran Tahir's googly clean bowls the batsman, Gemaal Hussain – and one of the bails flies freakishly into the keeper's eye.

I am fielding at cover and I rush in to celebrate the fall of the wicket with the rest of the team but, as I run, I see Bouch fall to the ground. I instantly know something is seriously wrong because, if I have learned anything in the past eight seasons, it is that he never goes down …

The legendary wicketkeeper is helped off the field by our physiotherapist and, that evening, undergoes surgery on his lacerated eye. We visit him in hospital and I remember how, even in these most terrible circumstances, he was still thinking of others, wishing us well.

It seemed so unfair. If he had not been injured in Taunton, if he had